during my stay of three years in the NDA did I have to take the re-examination. As a tradition in the final term, the passing-out cadets became the juniormost for a day or two. It was fun to see them being ragged by everyone. Generally, those who were very harsh or strict with their juniors were singled out for special treatment. When I was graduating, very few of the juniors came looking for me, and I got away lightly.

The Sino-Indian war took place during October-November 1962. This war over disputed borders came as a rude shock. I was in the fourth term at that time. All of us volunteered to go and fight for the defence of the motherland. I vividly recall that our deputy commandant, Brigadier Hoshiar Singh, a gallant soldier and an experienced war leader, was nominated to command a brigade under 4 Infantry Division in NEFA (now Arunachal Pradesh) and moved posthaste to the northeast. That brigade was tasked to occupy a defensive position at the formidable Se La pass.

We had great faith and confidence that his brigade would stall the Chinese advance and stem the tide. Unfortunately, the 4th Division withdrew from Se La without giving much of a fight. During this phase of the war, Brigadier Hoshiar Singh died in action against the Chinese. We as cadets felt very sad to lose such a fine officer, and it would be hard to forget those days. As a result of this debacle, quite a few heads rolled in the army, and the overall responsibility had to be accepted by the then defence minister, V.K. Krishna Menon, and the army chief, General P.N. Thapar. In a way, this setback to the image of India affected the stature of our first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru. He felt stabbed in the back by the Chinese. He never recovered from this catastrophic event and died due to a heart attack in 1964.

After their traumatic defeat in 1962, there was a large-scale expansion of the armed forces. To make up for the shortfall of officers, emergency commissions were given to a few thousand young men from 1963–65. They were given training at the academies for only six months instead of two years. At the same